Leadership Tool: Time Blocking

A truly powerful tool effective leaders utilize to allocate specific time slots for different tasks, ensure proper focus, remain highly productive, and prioritize tasks is called "time blocking." This time-management technique offers a number of benefits to leaders to maximize task completion and align different leadership priorities. The first benefit of time blocking is that it promotes increased productivity and task efficiency. By focusing on one task at a time, leaders can focus attention on the completion of one task without distractions. Limiting distractions from multitasking can increase concentration on a task, while saving time from having to start, stop, and then restart the same task. This approach allows leaders to engage in deep work, which enables the individual to complete the task quicker and with higher-quality outputs.

Secondly, the use of time blocking aids in the prioritization of the most important tasks to increase a leader's success. Leaders who dedicate the necessary time blocks to important activities ensure that these tasks are completed and not interrupted by less important tasks. This practice can help move daily important tasks to the next stage and ensure long-term goals are purposefully completed. Additionally, by time blocking, goals that do not have as much urgency but are highly important (personal and professional development) are not pushed back or forgotten due to other urgent but not important tasks. With a demand on a leader's time, the technique of time blocking ensures that valuable time is not wasted on low-value tasks while neglecting crucial ones.

Lastly, time blocking contributes to a reduction in stress and improves work-life balance. Time blocking can be successfully utilized to structure competing priorities and personal obligations. By intentionally designating time for competing work priorities, personal activities, and self-care, leaders can proactively structure their time to be present in the activity. The boundaries that are set up from time blocking prevent other work from encroaching on the competing task or on one's personal life. The practice of time blocking can enable leaders to maintain a healthy balance between work and their personal life, which contributes to well-being and prevents burnout. Overall, time blocking provides leaders with an avenue to make the most of their day, providing the necessary structure, accountability, and focus to maximize their time and effort.

Best Practices: Enhancing Your Time Blocking Effectiveness

Prior to diving into the different types of time blocking, it is valuable to understand some of the best practices when utilizing this tool to optimize productivity and manage time efficiently. To make the most of time blocking, leaders can employ the following strategies to enhance overall effectiveness of the tool.

- **Prioritize Most Critical Tasks** – Utilizing a tool like the Eisenhower Matrix, leaders should identify the highest-priority tasks they have for their work week. The highest priorities can be found in both the urgent/important or the not urgent/important part of the Eisenhower matrix. After the tasks for the week have been identified, focus on different higher-priority tasks with different time blocks on your schedule. By assigning these high-priority tasks leaders can ensure progress toward goals while avoiding getting caught up in less important activities. On Sunday night or Monday morning, make a list of your prioritized tasks and assign them accordingly in your schedule.
- **Batch Processing** – Leaders benefit from grouping similar tasks together within multiple time blocks. Utilizing this technique called "batch processing" leaders can minimize the time it takes to switch between tasks and leverage similar types of tasks to stay in the same mind frame. For example, by utilizing this clustering technique, leaders can streamline their workflow by addressing numerous types of administrative responsibilities together in time blocks like emails, sending out agendas, or data entry.
- **Buffer Time** – Allowing for a buffer time block at the end of the day provides for time to follow up on tasks the leader was unable to complete in the specific time block assigned during the day. This can act as a contingency period, providing flexibility, in case a task takes longer than expected. By purposefully planning for this buffer time, leaders can maintain a sense of control over their schedule and lessen anxiety of falling behind. If the time blocks go as scheduled throughout the day (which will happen most often), leaders can utilize the buffer time to schedule the following day or take on another not urgent but important task.
- **Schedule Regular Breaks** – Best practices suggest scheduling breaks that are compatible with the length of the time block you select. For every 25 minutes that you time block for a task you should also schedule at least a five-minute break. These breaks can help to prevent burnout and help the leader maintain focus by restoring mental energy. Breaks can include walking, stretching, meditation, or getting a healthy snack. Without breaks, diminishing returns on time spent will occur and leaders will spend significantly more time trying to accomplish tasks.

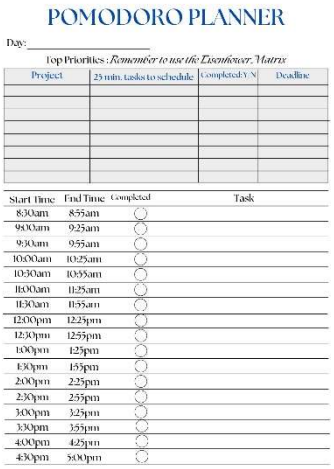
Taking these best practices into account it is time to discuss the different time blocking techniques. The success of each technique is dependent on the individual utilizing the tool. Remember, take time to try each of the techniques with your schedule and find the one that works best for you in your particular context.

Types of Time Blocking

Time management is incredibly important for successful leaders and time blocking techniques structure time, in different ways, to cater to different preferences, contexts and work styles. The following are four different styles of time blocking. After reading each style, decide for yourself which style works best for you. Additionally, try to utilize different techniques together to optimize the time blocking technique that works with your style and context.

The Pomodoro Technique

The first of the time blocking techniques is the Pomodoro Technique and is founded on the principle of working in concentrated, uninterrupted, intervals. Typically, the Pomodoro technique is 25-minutes of blocked uninterrupted time spent on one task, followed by a 5-minute break. Once the 25-minute block and 5-minute break is completed, the leader is to move on to the next task. After the leader has completed 4 consecutive Pomodoros, it is recommended that a longer break is taken to rest and recharge.



POMODORO PLANNER

Day: _____

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2:30pm	2:55pm	◯	
3:00pm	3:25pm	◯	
3:30pm	3:55pm	◯	
4:00pm	4:25pm	◯	
4:30pm	5:00pm	◯	

See Pomodoro Planner Below

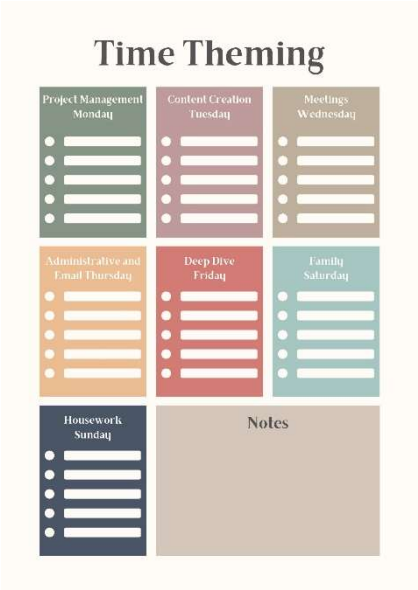
For leaders selecting the Pomodoro Technique for time blocking it is important to begin each day breaking down high prioritized tasks into smaller, manageable segments that can be completed in a 25-minute periods of time. The premise behind the Pomodoro Technique is that a leader will fill the time they have with the work they need to get done. If a leader is provided 25-minutes for a task, then the task will be completed within 25-minutes. If the leader has 60-minutes for the same task, it is suggested that the leader will fill up the 60-minutes with the same task. By providing urgency to the work, the Pomodoro Technique ensures that the leader will stay focused on the task. However, it is critical that leaders utilizing this technique commit to uninterrupted time, which can require communicating the needs of the leader to others.

While there are several benefits, the Pomodoro Technique can pose challenges in certain contexts. Environments where unexpected interruptions or urgent matters happen frequently can cause disruptions in the leader's rhythm, requiring them to adapt and restart continuously. Additionally, some tasks may be more complex or require extended focus and therefore cannot be completed in the allotted time. This can lead to the individual feeling guilty about running over the time limit or them choosing to resist taking breaks, especially when tasks completion seems urgent. In these cases, another time blocking technique might be more effective. Finally, the Pomodoro Technique tends to be an individual process, which can limit the communication and collaboration needed with others they are leading. Typically, leaders will limit the use of the Pomodoro Technique to half day sessions or selecting particular days of the week.

The Time Theming Technique

The Time Theming Technique is based on the organization of a leader's workday into distinct themes or categories of different tasks. As an alternative to reacting to tasks as they arise, The Time Theming Technique allocates specific time blocks to different types of work. This enables leaders to take a deeper focus when necessary or stay within an administrative mindset if that is the purpose of the block. For example, Mondays might be allocated to strategic planning, Tuesdays for team meetings, and Wednesdays for deep work on individual projects. Time theming ensures that each aspect of work receives dedicated attention, allowing individuals to maintain focus and prevent task overload.

If a leader choices Time Theming as a best practice for blocking time throughout their day or week, it is important that themes or categories are identified, dedicated time is scheduled for different themes, and then tasks are aligned with each of the themes to ensure they are completed during their designated block. When engaging in Time Theming it is important to prioritize themes (and the amount of blocked time per theme) based on leadership responsibilities and organizational objectives. By ensuring that themes are aligned with the important areas of the Eisenhower Matrix, leaders can optimize effort and save time throughout the week. Additionally, blocking time to address themes should be scheduled during peak energy and focus periods. Each leader has these times throughout the day, and it is critically important they are used to address the themes to maximize effectiveness. Finally, constant communication with others on when items can be completed, based on when themes are scheduled, is important to manage other's expectations.

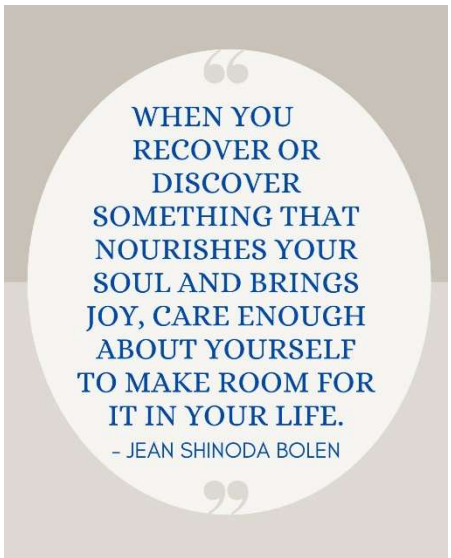


The major challenge associated with the Time Theming Technique is based on urgent and important tasks that arise, which need to be addressed prior to the next block session around that theme. Balancing flexibility to address these tasks or issues, while also adhering to the Time Theming blocks, can be challenging and often leads to less structured efforts. Additionally, coordinating team-based projects based on a Time Theming schedule can make it difficult on others waiting for specific deliverables. In both cases, it is important to experiment with this technique to find balance that works for you and others. By going through an initial period of trial and error, leaders can find a theme-based block schedule that works effectively for themselves and others.

The Fixed-Schedule Technique

The Fixed Schedule Technique establishes a structured daily or weekly schedule that blocks all time for work-related tasks, personal activities, self-care, deep work sessions, and professional growth opportunities. This technique relies heavily on the establishment of clear boundaries for work hours, the prioritization of personal activities and mindful allocation of time

blocks for different types of strategic work. Working with a Fixed-Schedule Technique for time blocking usually is a multi-week process balancing all the necessary personal and professional activities. The key to the Fixed-Schedule Technique involves scheduling every hour of the day, including planned breaks and personal activities. This technique emphasizes the importance of scheduling leisure and personal time alongside work commitments, helping individuals achieve work-life balance and prevent burnout.



Different than the Pomodoro Technique or the Time Theming Technique, the Fixed Schedule takes more of a holistic approach to scheduling time blocks for the leader. Since this is the case, utilizing the Eisenhower matrix to prioritize tasks will also need to consider a holistic approach. Both urgent/important and not urgent/important categories will need to be mindful of both personal and professional tasks or activities. On the work side, leaders need to allocate time blocks for various critical leadership tasks, including strategic planning, addressing customer concerns, high priority meetings, and problem solving. Additionally, leaders need to block out time to address personal activities and self-care to maintain a healthy work-life balance. While a perfect balance between the two is unreasonable, leaders should work towards balance over extended periods of time.

Like the other techniques, the Fixed Schedule techniques has some challenges that leaders can encounter, especially when they deal with unpredictable work demands or are consistently addressing time sensitive urgent matters. Often trying to adhere to a Fixed Schedule, in this type of context, can cause more stress for the leader than utilizing other techniques. Additionally, coordinating with team members who have different schedules or are in different time zones may pose logistical challenges to a Fixed Schedule approach. However, no matter what culture or pressures, every effective leader needs to find time to prioritize their personal activities and self-care. Whether a Fixed Schedule works for you as a leader or you utilize another technique for time blocking, make sure to find personal time for yourself to prevent burnout.

The Power Hour Technique

The final time blocking technique is the Power Hour Technique and operates by dedicating a distraction-free hour(s) for concentrated work on not urgent but important tasks daily. In Power Hour time blocking, leaders set aside one-hour at the same time each day, based on their peak energy time, to engage in strategic thinking, complex problem solving, creativity, relationship building, or professional development. Ideally, when utilizing this time blocking technique, the leader will have five different, one-hour sessions (in a five-day work week structure) to address each of the not urgent but important tasks described above.

Best practices suggest that leaders utilizing the Power Hour Technique keep a routine schedule that allocates at least one hour a day, usually at the same time, to a dedicated task. Week after week, the leader will continue to engage in similar activities during that particular day and time.

For example, if Tuesday at 9:00am is dedicated to professional development, then the leader would block out their schedule for the next month for professional development on Tuesday at 9:00am. The repetition of the Power Hour ensures that the not urgent but significantly important roles/responsibilities of being an effective leader are not pushed off due to urgent but not important matters. Additionally, each Power Hour time block should have 1 or 2 objectives dedicated to the hour, with measurable goals associated, to keep the leader accountable. Both the objective(s) and the measurable goals should be established prior to the beginning of the hour.

While the challenges associated with the Power Hour Technique are similar to other time blocking techniques, there are also some unique challenges that a leader will need to consider. First, leaders that utilize numerous "power hours" throughout a day may find that without the proper breaks, the repetition of mentally taxing work leads to quicker burnout. Breaks are critical if more than one "power hour" is used in a day. Additionally, unexpected life circumstances and urgent work may arise requiring the leader to make difficult decisions about keeping their power hour time block. If a block is missed, the not urgent but important work assigned to that block will be pushed back to the following week. Often, perception of the importance of the particular task comes into play and too often the more a power hour is missed, the easier it is to miss the next week. It is recommended for leaders utilizing this time blocking technique that once a schedule is created, they do everything in their "power" to remain committed to the power hour assigned.

Long Term Success

Leaders who utilize time blocking often find that they save time and accomplish more throughout the day. Yet, which time blocking technique works best for a leader is unique to their leadership style and the work context they are leading. It is important to foster a growth mindset to overcome challenges and maintain long-term success utilizing this time management tool. Remember, leadership and effective use of this tool is like a laboratory. Develop a time blocking system that you believe will work for you and put it into practice. After you have engaged in the practice, collect the necessary data (reflection, opinion from others, etc.) so that you can make meaningful and purposeful decisions about how to change the practice to benefit your leadership. Then repeat this process until you find a model of time blocking that works best for you.

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